bureaucrat's claim, Kaarthikeyan didn't pay heed to it. He knew the politics behind such queries. However, he also knew the sensational claim one of the assassins in custody had made during interrogation—that on 17 May, four days before the assassination, Sivarasan had met a person at the hideout in Jayakumar's house in MR Nagar at Kodungaiyur. Sivarasan had introduced the guest as Srinivasa Aiyya. After an hour-long talk on the open terrace, Sivarasan had come down to see off his guest. The guest had expressed his hope that Sivarasan would help them see Vaiko as chief minister of Tamil Nadu soon. To that, Sivarasan had said, 'Once this mission is over.'

Anirudhya tried to meet Karunanidhi again with a written questionnaire that his Madras office had already made available to the politician's office. But citing ill health, the leader had stayed away from answering *India Today*'s questions. Once he returned to Madras, Anirudhya sensed a clear polarization of opinions brewing in the SIT. Officers such as Kanth, Verma and Ragothaman felt the direction of their investigation was being influenced by an agenda. The probe was being remote-controlled to ensure it was a case of one victim and one murderer. The victim was Rajiv Gandhi and the murderer the LTTE—and that would be the end of the story. Any other complicity and angle of conspiracy had to be kept aside. And if anyone was clear about it, it was the boss, Kaarthikeyan.

The SIT had not explored several leads, including the ones that had pointed to a nexus between the assassins and certain members of the DMK. Anirudhya asked Kaarthikeyan about it and his reply was instant: 'Some with vested interests have been trying to derail the remarkable job done by my men by planting stories about a larger conspiracy. The SIT is investigating a murder case. The accused have been produced in court, taken on remand and further investigation to prove the murder is on.' New Delhi had set up separate inquiry commissions to look into any such allegation that fell outside the purview of his team. 'The SIT will prove the charges in court and secure the conviction of the accused,' he added. 'The SIT need not be taught its role.' He did not see the SIT ignoring any avenue that could establish the charges.